

My father William Edward Schmiedt, was born in Kittery Maine a short distance north of Boston Mass.

He never said much about his childhood except that he grew up along the "Water-Front" and was quite familiar with different kinds of sailing ships and their sails and rigging. He was familiar with the many knots the sailors used on the ropes.

He never mentioned his father and his mother was involved in a horse and buggy accident and was in a wheel-chair the rest of her life.

When the Spanish American War broke out he enlisted and after a short period of training was sent to Cuba where he promptly caught the "fever" and was hospitalized and then sent home.

He never forgot the Army training and always walked with a stiff upright



posture. All his life he had a great respect for the military and loyalty to the government.

When he was about thirty years of age he went to Kansas. His sister had married an engineer who was building bridges in Washington County Kansas and he worked for him awhile.

While building a bridge next to my grand-father's homestead on the Little Blue River near Hanover Kansas he met and soon married my mother Madge Oswald.

They set up house-keeping in Washington Kansas where they lived for thirty five years and had six sons.

He tried several jobs and then became a partner in a steam laundry and became a very good Laundry-man.

In those days everyone did their own wash on a wash-board and had galvanized tubs. The few washing machines



were crude hand or foot powered. The fashion of the day demanded starched collars and cuffs that only professionals could do. There were also elaborate short-waisted and bouffant sleeves and lace trim for the women.

There was a large gas engine that powered the presses and mangles all connected by pulleys and belts.

The washing machines were huge cylindrical wooden tubs that rotated in one direction for awhile and then reversed.

The "extractor", was a barrel like machine that whirled the clothes until they were clamp-dry. A large boiler supplied steam and hot water.

The clothes were dried in a Drying-room hung on lines close together. The room was heated to a high degree but it took quite a long time to dry. Women did much of the work.



In those days there were few women who had jobs outside the home and the pay was small.

The hard collars were in varied sizes and heights, some near three inches high and held the head quite rigid. They were held on the shirt with two small "Collar Buttons" which were hard to fasten and easily lost when in a hurry.

These collars could only be prepared in a laundry. They were washed in very hot water to remove the old starch then a strong bleach was used to make them snow-white. They were then starched and partially dried and then ironed with special irons that would fold and curl them into shape. This was before electric irons.

The shirts also received special attention with cuffs stiffly starched



and immaculately ironed. Women would stand hour after hour ironing shirt after shirt all day long. They were then carefully folded and held with a paper band till worn.

I can recall going to visit the laundry when I was very young and they would give me some small chore to do and then give me a nickel which I took to the restaurant next door and the cook would have a small chocolate pie made just for me. I still like chocolate pie.

The laundry went broke. It was rumored that the partner had his hand in the till. I do know father was very discouraged.

Times were hard and jobs scarce and it was some time before dad was able to borrow a few dollars and buy an old Ford truck and went into the junk business.



As he learned ways to make money in the junk business he scoured the town and countryside for iron, rags, rubber and metals. All had to be cleaned and separated and boxed for shipment. Farm machinery was taken apart and hauled in. Old automobiles were taken apart piece by piece and some parts salvaged. It took a lot of trips to accumulate the sixty or seventy tons of iron for a car load and he shipped a number of cars every year for a number of years.

Even with lots of work money was scarce and it was tough to feed and buy shoes for a bunch of growing boys.

Eventually mother sold the western land she had inherited and they paid off debts and bought a small acreage on the edge of town with a nice house and garden.

and fruit trees. They raised some chickens and got a cow so living was more secure.

Dad wasent getting any younger and time was takeing its toll on both mom and dad and the winters were harsh and letters from mothers sister in California made things sound so good out there they decided to make gamble.

It was still deep in the "Depression" and they sold everything and loaded a Ford truck with essentials and headed west.